

History & Folklore Kuth root has been used in Indian medicine for at least 2,500 years. It has also been exported to China and the Middle East. The fragrant root is often used in perfumery. In India, it is valued as an aphrodisiac and for its reputed ability to prevent gray hair.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Kuth is used in the Ayurvedic and Unani Tibb traditions in India for its tonic, stimulant, and antiseptic properties. The root is commonly taken, in combination with other herbs, for respiratory system problems such as bronchitis, asthma, and coughs. It is also used to treat cholera.

Related species *S. amara* is used in Mongolian herbal medicine to treat bacterial infections and gallbladder disease.

Caution Do not take kuth essential oil internally.

Schizonepeta tenuifolia (Lamiaceae)

Jing jie

Description Perennial plant growing to 26 ft (8 m) with upright square stems, lance-shaped leaves, and whorls of small flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Far East, *jing jie* is widely cultivated in eastern China. The aerial parts of the plant are gathered in autumn.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents *Jing jie* contains a volatile oil, the main constituents of which are menthone and limonene.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In the Chinese tradition, *jing jie* is valued as an aromatic and warming herb. It is taken to alleviate skin conditions such as boils and itchiness. *Jing jie* also induces sweating and is used to treat fever and chills, and as a remedy for measles. It is often combined with *bo he* (*Mentha haplocalyx*, p. 234).

Research Chinese studies have confirmed *jing jie*'s ability to increase blood flow in the vessels just beneath the skin.

Scolopendrium vulgare (Polypodiaceae)

Hartstongue

Description Evergreen fern growing to 2 ft (60 cm). Has long, tongue-shaped fronds with twin rows of spores on the underside.

Habitat & Cultivation Hartstongue is found throughout much of Europe, North Africa, East Asia, and North America. It prefers shaded sites in woodlands and on banks and walls. The fronds are gathered throughout the summer.

Parts Used Fronds.



Hartstongue is found growing in shady woodland sites across the northern hemisphere.

Constituents Hartstongue contains tannins, mucilage, and flavonoids (including leucodelphinidin).

History & Folklore Hartstongue has been prescribed as a treatment for diarrhea and dysentery for at least 2,000 years. In Wales and the Scottish Highlands, it was traditionally used as a poultice for wounds, scalds, and burns, and as an ointment for hemorrhoids. In Japan, the fronds were smoked by the Ainu people.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Hartstongue was valued in the past for its ability to heal wounds, but today it is employed chiefly as a mild astringent. It is sometimes used in the treatment of diarrhea and IBS, and it may be of benefit to the liver and spleen. Hartstongue appears to have expectorant properties, and it is also mildly diuretic.

Scrophularia nodosa (Scrophulariaceae)

Figwort

Description Upright perennial herb growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has a square stem, oval leaves, small round brown flowers in clusters, and green seed capsules.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, Central Asia, and North America, figwort thrives in wet or damp places, in open woodland, on riverbanks, and alongside ditches. The herb is gathered in the summer while in flower.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Figwort contains iridoids (including aucubin, harpagoside, and acetyl harpagide), flavonoids, cardioactive glycosides, and phenolic acids. Harpagoside and harpagide are thought to account for its antiarthritic activity.

History & Folklore Figwort's genus name, *Scrophularia*, alludes to the plant's age-old use as a treatment for scrofula. In this condition, the lymph

nodes of the neck, infected with tuberculosis, swell to form hard protruding lumps beneath the skin. Figwort root resembles these swollen glands and therefore, according to the Doctrine of Signatures (which holds that a plant's appearance indicates the ailments it treats), the herb was considered to be an appropriate remedy for treating scrofula. Indeed, in the 16th and 17th centuries, figwort was esteemed as the best medicinal plant to help relieve all manner of swellings and tumors.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Figwort is an herb that supports detoxification of the body and may be used as a treatment for various types of skin conditions. Taken internally as an infusion or applied externally, figwort is of value in treating chronic skin diseases such as eczema and psoriasis. Applied externally, it will also help speed the healing of burns, wounds, hemorrhoids, and ulcers. The traditional use of figwort as a treatment for swellings and tumors continues in Europe to this day. The herb is also mildly diuretic, and it is reputed to be effective when used to expel worms.

Related Species Water figwort (*S. aquatica*), another plant that is native to Europe, has similar properties, as does the American *S. marylandica*. In China, *S. ningopoensis* is used to treat infections and to clear toxicity.

Caution Do not take figwort if suffering from a heart condition.

Selenicereus grandiflorus (Cactaceae)

Night-blooming Cereus

Description Climbing multibranched perennial cactus with upright cylindrical stems and aerial roots. Produces large flowerbuds opening into night-blooming white flowers that grow to 8 in (20 cm) across, and red oval fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Mexico and Central America, night-blooming cereus is now rarely found in the wild. It is cultivated both as an ornamental and a medicinal plant. The flowers and young stems are gathered in summer.

Parts Used Flowers, young stems.

Constituents Night-blooming cereus contains alkaloids (including cactine), flavonoids (isorhamnetin), and a pigment. Cactine's cardiotoxic effect is considered similar to that of cardiac glycosides (see foxglove, *Digitalis* species, p. 202).

Medicinal Actions & Uses As it is in short supply, night-blooming cereus is little used at present, but it is a valuable remedy for the heart. It stimulates the action of the heart, increasing the strength of contractions while slowing heart rate. It is prescribed as a treatment for various conditions,